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Not everyone is excited by technology. Some people will do anything to get away from it, especially the pests disguised as mobile devices. Smart phones and dumb, the latest to the dated, from Nokias to Siemens, phones will always ring. Like sadistic children, they will always disturb you when you least want them to. Even if you turn the darn things on silent, they will vibrate so violently in

your pocket that people start calling you Elvis.

Bet you are wishing you could take a sledge hammer to your mobile right now, right? Hang on, not so fast...

What's gorgeous, has long legs, a beautiful smile, and for the right price, will let you watch as she does your bidding? All right, *STOP!* Get that mind out of the gutter! We are talking about the models at smashmyphone.com. Anyone can break their own phones—and many have; but nothing beats sending your phone to smashmyphone.com, choosing one of the exquisite female “technicians” and then waiting for your video clip and photographs. You will get the pleasure of watching your phone get “fixed” (for good!) by the gorgeous technician! Actually there is something that beats that—getting your colleagues’ or wife’s or nagging relative’s phone “fixed” would be a lot more fun. Remember, you can also make special requests, like asking the model to drive her sports car over your irritating phone, or stamping it with her heels, using hammers, etc.

Robert Sovereign-Smith

Lee Harvey Oswald and fire at President Kennedy’s motorcade, has been condemned as “despicable” by the former US President’s family. The player who most accurately recreates Oswald’s three fatal shots will win a \$100,000 competition.

The game was released on the Net to coincide with the 41st anniversary of JFK’s assassination in Dallas. Software company Traffic, which created the game, claims it will help dispel the conspiracy theories that surround JFK’s death.

ONLINE CREMATION

Indian Site To Screen Funerals Online

Designers of an Indian high-tech crematorium say they will soon screen funerals online, so that

non-resident Gujaratis in the US, the UK, and other places, who can’t make it, will be able to watch the last rites of their loved ones. The Web site will be called www.mokshadham.org. The site is expected to be live by June.

The scheme is part of a high tech crematorium to be built in Vadodara and funded by Indian Petrochemicals. The other undertakers are the Vadodara Municipal Corporation (VMC) and the local Rotary Club.

Funerals will be broadcast on the Web only upon the request of relatives. A fee will be charged, and only registered users will be allowed to watch the cremation. Users can also e-mail condolence messages and chat with relatives. The facilities would be offered to non-resident Gujaratis and their family members locally for a nominal fee, said a VMC official. ■

Compiled by Ram Mohan Rao

Blog WATCH

Here’s taking a look at a few riveting posts from the world of blogs. This month, there’s stuff about “Robust Statistics”—which, some say, is a technique that was able to predict the US election results with almost 100 per cent accuracy. Then there’s something about *Amar Chitra Katha*—if you are old enough, you probably know the series. We also take a look at two serious privacy concerns.

BoingBoing

<http://snipurl.com/awtn>

The Ramayana in comic-book form

Avi Solomon says, “*Ramayana*, the classic Indian epic, is online in ‘graphic novel’ form! This is part of the *Amar Chitra Katha* series conceived by Anant Pai, who was the pioneer in using comics to reintroduce India’s mythological and historical treasures to its alienated youth.

BoingBoing reader Suresh Venkat says, “Many Indians of a certain age—myself included—grew up devouring *Amar Chitra Katha*. I didn’t realize that they count as ‘graphic novels.’ I guess I was on the cutting edge even then ...”

Suresh

<http://snipurl.com/awto>

A victory for robust statistics?

In all the brouhaha over election predictions, it is worth observing that robust statistics scored a clear victory. According to Wes Colley and J. Richard Gott, merely taking the median of all polls in the last month was good enough to predict the election outcome with almost 100 per cent accuracy.

So what is a robust statistic? One way of defining it is that it is a statistic on a set of numbers that requires at least a constant fraction of the input to go to infinity before the statistic itself goes to infinity. For the median, this number is 50 per cent; however, only one number needs to go to infinity to pull the mean along with it.

John Battelle

<http://snipurl.com/awtp>

As Search History Develops, an Implication or Two

The Palo Alto Medical Foundation is warning against the use of Google Desktop. The Foundation even published a FAQ about it. From that document:

“How does this affect me? If this tool has been installed on a PC that you are using, it is possible for your private health information viewed through PAMFOnline to be cached on the computer’s hard drive and retrieved later by someone else.

“What can I do about it? If you uncheck the “Include Secure Pages (HTTPS)” option, the tool will no longer be able to retrieve secure PAMFOnline pages.

This is one example of what I am sure will be a long, slow awakening to the power and potential of having search history in our lives.”

BoingBoing

<http://snipurl.com/awtp>

Color laser printers add hidden ID number to printouts

Colour laser printer manufacturers encode each printout with the printer’s serial number so they can trace it back to you if you are counterfeiting bills. They can trace it back to you for anything else as well. How long have they been doing this? Why isn’t it common knowledge? What other ways to track our lives have been implemented without a big announcement?